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WAM

136,891 TONNES OF HUMANITARIAN AID DELIVERED TO GAZA

In Gaza, the UAE has emerged as one of the largest providers of humanitarian aid, contributing nearly half of all international assistance entering the Strip through air, land, and sea. Till date, the UAE has delivered 136,891 tonnes of humanitarian aid to Gaza in 14,442 trucks since the launch of Operation Gallant Knight 3, as the humanitarian mission approaches its third anniversary.

SEE ALSO P5

Bank customers in UAE receive Dh16b financial relief on loans

Central bank defers loans for 155,971 individuals, SMEs and large corporates

DUBAI
BY STACY PEREIRA
Business Reporter

The Central Bank of UAE (CBUAE) has granted financial relief to 155,971 bank customers nationwide. The measures cover loans worth Dh15.9 billion (\$4.33 billion) and run through the end of August. Individuals form the largest group. A total of 148,681 retail customers received repayment deferrals worth Dh2.3 billion (\$626 million).

The regulator disclosed the figures on October 5 after Gov-

ernor Khaled Mohamed Balama met chief executives of banks operating in the UAE.

About 849 private sector companies received Dh10.7 billion or \$2.91 billion in support. Another 6,441 small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) secured deferrals worth Dh2.9 billion or \$790 million. The package also waives commissions and fees.

Protecting business growth

The CBUAE launched the Financial Institutions Resilience Package (FIRP) in March. This came on the back of the regional conflict that broke out on February 28. With the scheme, the central bank aims to protect business growth and the wider economy.

Borrowers made the most of such schemes. On May 8, data

showed 65,300 customers had benefited from relief worth Dh6.2 billion (\$1.69 billion). By July 30, deferrals reached Dh13.5 billion (\$3.68 billion) across 135,031 customers. Lenders including Abu Dhabi Islamic Bank and Emirates NBD ran their own schemes alongside, offering deferrals and fee waivers.

Banks held firm throughout. Assets rose 12.9 per cent year-on-year by the end of August. Lending jumped 18.8 per cent, and deposits grew 13 per cent. The non-performing loan ratio fell to 2.6 per cent, while the net ratio improved to 1.2 per cent.

Balama urged lenders to speed up digital transformation, strengthen consumer protection and widen financial inclusion. He also called for tight governance, risk management and compliance.

New Dubai signage: Blue near sea, gold near desert

Emirate's addressing system gets a fresh visual identity

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Residents in Dubai will soon see new area identification signs, internal street name signs and house plates in unified designs.

A new visual identity for the emirate's addressing system, with signs and house number plates being replaced across 186 areas by 2030, is being undertaken by the Supreme Committee for Urban Planning, in coordination with the Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) and Dubai Municipality.

Developed through a specialist consultant in wayfinding and addressing design, the new system will help facilitate the identification of locations and improve accessibility, while enhancing the visual appeal of streets, residential neighbourhoods,

and commercial districts. The new visual identity incorporates five colours specifically designed to reflect the character and geographic features of Dubai's various areas, providing each with a distinctive visual signature while maintaining a clear and consistent addressing system across the emirate.

Aligned with nature

The selected colours have been carefully aligned with the nature of each area. For example, blue represents areas located close to the sea, while gold symbolises areas characterised by a desert environment, reflecting the diversity of Dubai's landscapes and urban fabric.

The new identity encompasses sector and area identification signs, internal street name signs, and house number plates, with designs and colour schemes developed to achieve visual integration across all components of the addressing system.

SEE ALSO P4

UAE tops digital government satisfaction

76% BELIEVE DIGITAL GOVERNMENT SERVICES SURPASS PRIVATE SECTOR

ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

The UAE has ranked first globally in citizen satisfaction with digital government services, according to the 2026 Citizen Survey on Digital Government by Boston Consulting Group (BCG), with 89 per cent of respondents giving the UAE a high rating.

Sharing details of the achievement in a post on X, His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, said, "Contrary to the global trend, more than 75 per cent believe that UAE government services outperform the digital services provided by the private sector. We are proud of our teams, proud of our journey to make people's lives easier, and proud of our country, which provides the world's best services to its citizens, visitors and residents."

'Best yet to come'

Sheikh Mohammed added, "The best is yet to come, God willing. Next November, the UAE government will unveil, through a major event, the biggest transformation yet in the way its services are structured and delivered to the public."

The survey, which covered 44 countries, found that the UAE ranked first in the use of digital government services, with 53

per cent of respondents reporting that they use such services.

Meanwhile, 76 per cent of respondents in the UAE said their most recent digital government transaction provided them with a better experience than they typically receive when dealing with private-sector organisations.

Strong digital foundation

This strong digital foundation is increasingly extending to the adoption of artificial intelligence. Eighty-two per cent of respondents in the UAE said they use AI on a weekly basis, while 53 per cent believe that the benefits of deploying AI in government outweigh the risks. This compares with 49 per cent across the GCC and 36 per cent globally.

At the GCC level, the report found strong demand for the next generation of AI-powered government services. The region is the world's most receptive to AI, with 79 per cent of citizens expressing openness to interacting with AI-enabled government services, compared with 66 per cent globally.

According to the report, three of the four government AI applications receiving the highest levels of support involve AI-agent use cases, representing a promising starting point for governments.

Half of respondents across the GCC said they prefer AI for simple services and human involvement for more complex services.

UAE slams Houthi strikes on Saudi Arabia

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE has strongly condemned the Houthi group's continued attacks on civilians and civilian and economic facilities in Saudi Arabia, as well as attacks on Saudi vessels in the southern Red Sea and the Bab Al Mandab Strait.

In a statement yesterday, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) said the attacks are a flagrant violation of Saudi Arabia's sovereignty and a threat to its security and stability.

The Saudi-led coalition said yesterday it had shot down a ballistic missile north of Riyadh.

"A ballistic missile launched by the terrorist Houthi militia north of Riyadh was intercepted and destroyed," coalition spokesman Major General Turki Al Maliki wrote on X.

Key meeting

Saudi Arabia's Chief of Naval Staff, Lieutenant General Mohammed Al Gharibi, yesterday received Vice Admiral Curt Renshaw, Commander of US Naval Forces Central Command and the US Fifth Fleet.

During the meeting, the two commanders discussed naval cooperation between Saudi Arabia and the United States in support of their mutual interests. They also reviewed ways to strengthen maritime security and safeguard freedom of navigation in the region.

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